

THE HARAPPAN CIVILIZATION

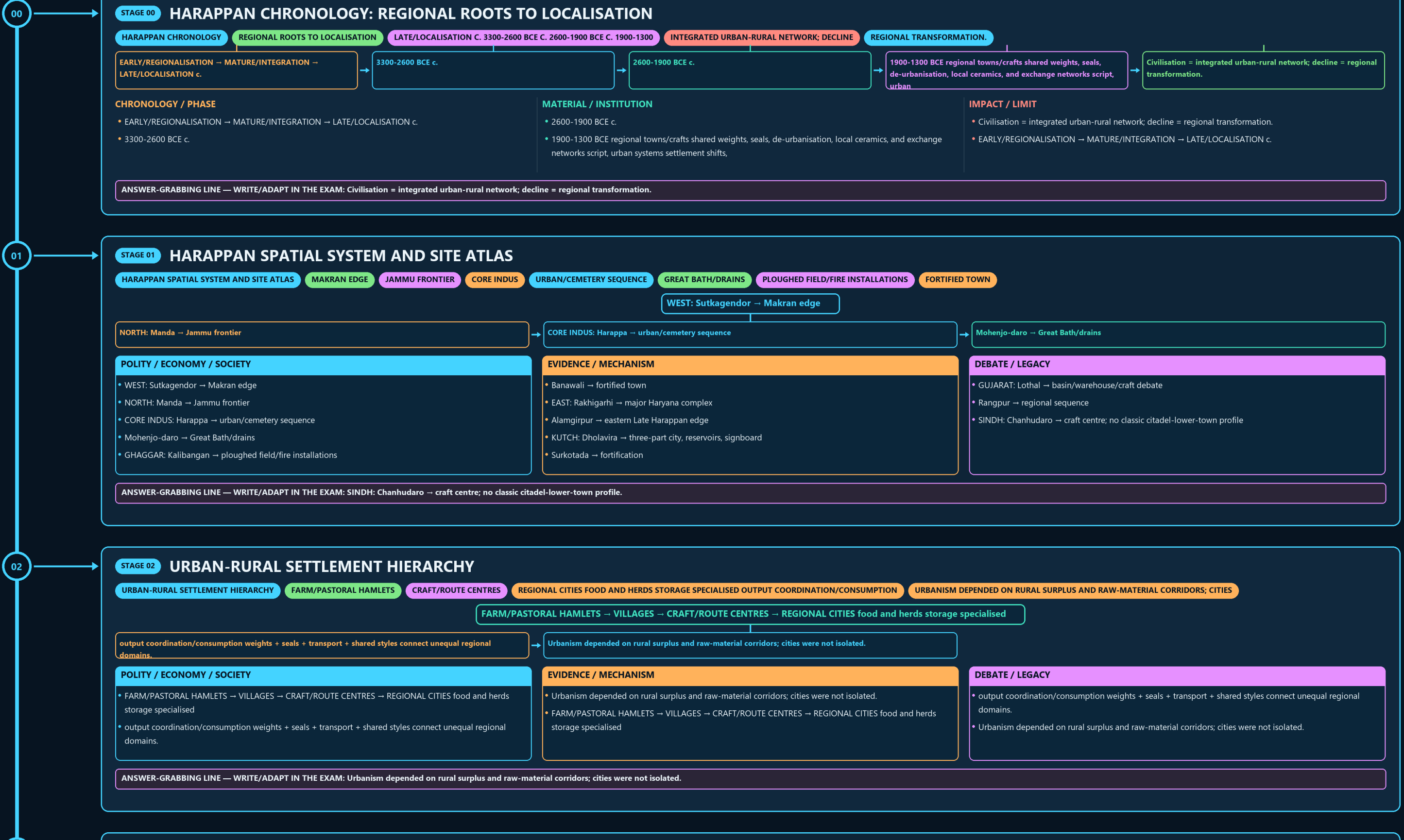
HARAPPAN CHRONOLOGY: REGIONAL ROOTS → HARAPPAN SPATIAL SYSTEM AND → URBAN-RURAL SETTLEMENT HIERARCHY → BUILT ORDER, WATER AND → THE HARAPPAN ECONOMY AS → INTERNAL AND OVERSEAS EXCHANGE

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

PRIMARY CORE FLOW SUBORDINATE EXTRA APPROVAL / REVIEW

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation g15 and all prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles



- FARM/PASTORAL HAMLETS → VILLAGES → CRAFT/ROUTE CENTRES → REGIONAL CITIES food and herds storage specialised
- output coordination/consumption weights + seals + transport + shared styles connect unequal regional domains.

- Urbanism depended on rural surplus and raw-material corridors; cities were not isolated.
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STAGE 03 BUILT ORDER, WATER AND CIVIC MAINTENANCE

SOAK PITS/INSPECTION ACCESS HOUSEHOLD INVESTMENT COLLECTIVE MAINTENANCE

PLANNED STREETS + STANDARD BRICKS + PLATFORMS + COURTYARD HOUSES wells/reservoirs → bathing

→ areas → covered drains → soak pits/inspection access household investment collective maintenance

→ **Dholavira adapts reservoirs to aridity; Mohenjo-daro stresses wells and drains.**

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- Dholavira adapts reservoirs to aridity; Mohenjo-daro stresses wells and drains.

STAGE 04 THE HARAPPAN ECONOMY AS A LINKED SYSTEM

BEADS, SHELL, FAIENCE, POTTERY, COPPER/BRONZE; STONE REMAINS IMPORTANT.

AGRICULTURAL-PASTORAL BASE wheat/barley cattle cotton fishing/regional crops

SURPLUS → craft workshops → calibrated weights → seals/transport → exchange

► **CRAFTS:** beads, shell, faience, pottery, copper/bronze; stone remains important.

- AGRICULTURAL-PASTORAL BASE wheat/barley cattle cotton fishing/regional crops
- SURPLUS → craft workshops → calibrated weights → seals/transport → exchange

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- CRAFTS: beads, shell, faience, pottery, copper/bronze; stone remains important.

STAGE 05 INTERNAL AND OVERSEAS EXCHANGE CORRIDORS

MESOPOTAMIA; MELUHHA IN CUNEIFORM TEXTS

RAW MATERIAL FLOW

Baluchistan/Afghanistan → metals/stones → Indus cities

▶ **Rajasthan/Khetri → copper corridor → production zones**

- Gujarat/Kutch → shell, carnelian, coastal routes → crafts and ports

- RAW MATERIAL FLOW
- Baluchistan/Afghanistan → metals/stones → Indus cities
- Rajasthan/Khetri → copper corridor → production zones

- Gujarat/Kutch → siell, carnelian, coastal routes → crafts and ports
- Indus/Makran/Gulf → Dilmun/Magan → Mesopotamia; Meluhha in cuneiform texts
- Trade evidence = imports + texts + seals + production; it does not prove colonies.

- Lothal basin has dockyard/reservoir interpretations: state the debate.

STAGE 06 SOCIETY AND POLITY: EVIDENCE WITHOUT INVENTED KINGS

COORDINATED INSTITUTIONS ARE CERTAIN; EMPIRE-LEVEL SOVEREIGNTY IS UNPROVEN.

HISTORICAL RESULT

06

Rajasthan/Khetri → copper corridor → production zones

Trade evidence = imports + texts + seals + production; it does not prove colonies.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Lothal basin has dockyard/reservoir interpretations: state the debate.

STAGE 06

SOCIETY AND POLITY: EVIDENCE WITHOUT INVENTED KINGS

SOCIETY AND POLITY

EVIDENCE WITHOUT INVENTED KINGS

HOUSE VARIATION + SCARCE GOODS + CRAFT CONTROL +

NO SECURE PALACE, ROYAL TOMB OR DECIPHERED KING-LIST; HIERARCHY

COORDINATED INSTITUTIONS ARE CERTAIN; EMPIRE-LEVEL SOVEREIGNTY IS UNPROVEN.

SOURCE / MATERIAL

EVIDENCE: house variation + scarce goods + craft control + standards + public works centralised state?

city/regional states?

METHOD / DEBATE

corporate or mercantile elites?

NO secure palace, royal tomb or deciphered king-list; hierarchy existed, form is open.

HISTORICAL RESULT

VERDICT: coordinated institutions are certain; empire-level sovereignty is unproven.

EVIDENCE: house variation + scarce goods + craft control + standards + public works centralised state?

MECHANISM / VERDICT — VERDICT: coordinated institutions are certain; empire-level sovereignty is unproven.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: coordinated institutions are certain; empire-level sovereignty is unproven.

07

SCRIPT, SEALS AND RELIGION

EVIDENCE LADDER

SHORT SIGNS, SEALS/TABLETS, MOTIFS, RITUAL INSTALLATIONS, BURIALS, FIGURINES

IDENTITY/TRANSACTION MARKING AND DIFFERENTIATED RITUAL PRACTICES

SCRIPT LANGUAGE; PROTO-SHIVA; MOTHER-GODDESS SYSTEM; UNIVERSAL FIRE ALTARS

READING LATER HINDU DOCTRINE DIRECTLY INTO EVERY HARAPPAN IMAGE.

UNDECIPHERED SCRIPT BLOCKS DIRECT ACCESS TO OFFICE, BELIEF AND

USE OBJECT + CONTEXT + DISTRIBUTION BEFORE ANALOGY.

SOURCE / MATERIAL

SECURE: short signs, seals/tablets, motifs, ritual installations, burials, figurines

PROBABLE: identity/transaction marking and differentiated ritual practices

METHOD / DEBATE

DISPUTED: script language; proto-Shiva; mother-goddess system; universal fire altars

REJECT: reading later Hindu doctrine directly into every Harappan image.

HISTORICAL RESULT

Undeciphered script blocks direct access to office, belief and political vocabulary.

Use object + context + distribution before analogy.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Use object + context + distribution before analogy.

08

STAGE 08

DE-URBANISATION: INTERACTING REGIONAL CAUSES

INTERACTING REGIONAL CAUSES

RIVER SHIFTS/FLOODS + ARIDIFICATION + EXCHANGE CONTRACTION + MAINTENANCE

CITY CONTRACTION/ABANDONMENT

SETTLEMENT REDISTRIBUTION LOSS

SCRIPT, SEALS, LARGE CITIES CONTINUITY

CROPS, CRAFTS, VILLAGES

NO INVASION OR SINGLE RIVER EXPLAINS ALL REGIONS; TIMINGS

river shifts/floods + aridification + exchange contraction + maintenance stress weaker standards → city

contraction/abandonment → settlement redistribution loss: script, seals, large cities continuity: crops, crafts, villages

No invasion or single river explains all regions; timings and outcomes differ.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

river shifts/floods + aridification + exchange contraction + maintenance stress weaker standards → city

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EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

No invasion or single river explains all regions; timings and outcomes differ.

river shifts/floods + aridification + exchange contraction + maintenance stress weaker standards → city

DEBATE / LEGACY

contraction/abandonment → settlement redistribution loss: script, seals, large cities continuity: crops, crafts, villages

No invasion or single river explains all regions; timings and outcomes differ.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: No invasion or single river explains all regions; timings and outcomes differ.

09

STAGE 09

HARAPPAN ANSWER ARCHITECTURE: 10/15/20 MARKS

HARAPPAN ANSWER ARCHITECTURE

10/15/20 MARKS

10 MARKS

SITE-FEATURE TRIAD

INTERPRETATION CAUTION

15 MARKS

SPATIAL SYSTEM

URBAN FORM

10 MARKS: phase → site-feature triad → mechanism → interpretation caution

15 MARKS: chronology → spatial system → urban form → economy → polity/religion limits

20 MARKS: integration → site map → urban-rural economy → water/standards/trade

society-polity evidence → script/ritual limits → transformation

BENCHMARK: material uniformity indicates integration, not automatic political unity.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

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EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

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DEBATE / LEGACY

BENCHMARK: material uniformity indicates integration, not automatic political unity.

CLOSE: a varied civilisation coordinated by standards, exchange and maintenance.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CLOSE: a varied civilisation coordinated by standards, exchange and maintenance.

09

STAGE 09 HARAPPAN ANSWER ARCHITECTURE: 10/15/20 MARKS

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DEBATE / LEGACY

- BENCHMARK: material uniformity indicates integration, not automatic political unity.
- CLOSE: a varied civilisation coordinated by standards, exchange and maintenance.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CLOSE: a varied civilisation coordinated by standards, exchange and maintenance.

10

STAGE 10 EVIDENCE LADDER AND CONFIDENCE CONTROL

EVIDENCE LADDER AND CONFIDENCE CONTROL

EVIDENCE LADDER

1. SEPARATE EXCAVATED FACT FROM FUNCTION LABEL AND SOCIAL

2. ANCHOR EVERY CLAIM IN SITE, PHASE, CONTEXT, COMPARISON

3. THE UNDECIIPHERED SCRIPT LIMITS NAMED CLAIMS ABOUT LANGUAGE

HARAPPAN HISTORY IS STRONGEST ON MATERIAL SYSTEMS, WEAKEST ON

SOURCE / MATERIAL	METHOD / DEBATE	HISTORICAL RESULT
EVIDENCE LADDER	2. Anchor every claim in site, phase, context, comparison and regional variation.	VERDICT: Harappan history is strongest on material systems, weakest on named ideas.
1. Separate excavated fact from function label and social interpretation.	3. The undeciphered script limits named claims about language, rulers and doctrine.	EVIDENCE LADDER

SOURCE / MATERIAL

- EVIDENCE LADDER
- 1. Separate excavated fact from function label and social interpretation.

METHOD / DEBATE

- 2. Anchor every claim in site, phase, context, comparison and regional variation.
- 3. The undeciphered script limits named claims about language, rulers and doctrine.

HISTORICAL RESULT

- VERDICT: Harappan history is strongest on material systems, weakest on named ideas.
- EVIDENCE LADDER

MECHANISM / VERDICT — VERDICT: Harappan history is strongest on material systems, weakest on named ideas.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Harappan history is strongest on material systems, weakest on named ideas.

11

STAGE 11 EXAMINER TRAPS AND CONTESTED BOUNDARIES

EXAMINER TRAPS AND CONTESTED BOUNDARIES

CLOSE DISTINCTIONS

1. CITADEL, GRANARY, DOCKYARD, PRIEST-KING AND PASHUPATI ARE MODERN

2. HORSE EVIDENCE IS RARE AND DISPUTED; STANDARDISATION DOES

3. DEURBANISATION WAS REGIONAL AND MULTI-CAUSAL, NOT ONE INVASION

STATE THE SECURE EVIDENCE FIRST, THEN GRADE EACH INTERPRETATION.

CLOSE DISTINCTIONS

1. Citadel, granary, dockyard, Priest-King and Pashupati are modern labels.

2. Horse evidence is rare and disputed; standardisation does not prove one empire.

3. Deurbanisation was regional and multi-causal, not one invasion or drought.

VERDICT: State the secure evidence first, then grade each interpretation.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- CLOSE DISTINCTIONS
- 1. Citadel, granary, dockyard, Priest-King and Pashupati are modern labels.

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- 2. Horse evidence is rare and disputed; standardisation does not prove one empire.
- 3. Deurbanisation was regional and multi-causal, not one invasion or drought.

DEBATE / LEGACY

- VERDICT: State the secure evidence first, then grade each interpretation.
- CLOSE DISTINCTIONS

MECHANISM / VERDICT — VERDICT: State the secure evidence first, then grade each interpretation.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: State the secure evidence first, then grade each interpretation.

E

EXTRA SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT

1. SNAPSHOT & CORE IDEA

2. DEBATES & INTERPRETATIONS (HIGH-YIELD TABLE)

GENETICS AND HARAPPAN/VEDIC QUESTIONS — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

3. STUDY LINKS

4. MUST-KNOW FACTS (PRELIMS)

+ EXACT PYQ APPLICATION (2025 GS-I)

5. UPSC TRAPS

OPTIONAL SOURCE DEPTH

- Mini-timeline
- 1. Snapshot & core idea
- 2. Debates & interpretations (high-yield table)
- Genetics and Harappan/Vedic Questions — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

ADVANCED DEBATE

- 3. Study links
- 4. Must-Know Facts (Prelims)
- + Exact PYQ application (2025 GS-I)
- 5. UPSC Traps

LEGACY / NUANCE

- 7. Mains angles
- Optional Advanced Studios: Distinct Refinements — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]
- A1. Urbanism, Households and Craft — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]
- A2. Standardisation and Authority — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.